The Cup in the Mud

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 10

The lower strap dipped into muddy water while Nib checked the route book. Fern Lodge's envelope stayed dry inside its protective folio. Nib began to drag the bag away, then stopped when the wet strap pulled against its base. Lark pointed to a low dry stump nearby.

“My bag has dipped a toe in,” Nib remarked anxiously. “Let us lift the toe, not tip the bag,” Lark urged calmly.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **bag**

“Lowercase u has the short sound in cup and mud,” Lark modeled clearly. “Listen to cup and cap. The outside sounds stay the same while the middle changes. We've now met five short vowel sounds; we can listen for the one each word actually needs.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try cup, cut, mud, sun, tub. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read cup and cap in the kit,” Lark invited calmly. “Which one can scoop a little surface water away?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **Sam dug. Pat sat in mud.**

“Who sat in mud?” Lark asked gently. “What did the other friend do?”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Nib used the cup beside the strap while Lark brought the bag's handle onto its lifting hook. Together they lifted the bag clear and settled it on the stump without tipping its contents. Nib checked all three pockets. The only remaining invitation was dry. He clipped the muddy cup outside the protected message pocket before setting off again.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write u beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Your journal showed the bag lifted clear of the puddle. Beyond the muddy patch, sunlight warmed the Fern Lodge path. A sheltered rest would keep the crew comfortable before the final outward delivery.